Muyu He

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Education

M.S. Computer Science *University of Pennsylvania* Sept 2023 - May 2025

B.A. Philosophy *University of California, Los Angeles* Sept 2018 - Dec 2021

Publications

- **Do Value Vectors in Deep Layers Need Context from the Residual Stream?** 1 **EMNLP 2026**
  Muyu He[*], Yuchen Liu[*], Qingya Huang, Li Zhang [*]Equal contribution
  - Challenged the standard attention mechanism of computing value vectors from the residual stream, discovering that deep layers benefit from a context-free value vector that represents original token information, and that models decouple the optimal input for keys vs. values
  - Proposed a new attention variant that directly learns a value vector table for each of the last third of layers, eliminating the V cache entirely and surpassing standard attention on both validation loss and average scores across 21 benchmarks on two model sizes (135M and 780M)

- **YC-Bench: Benchmarking AI Agents for Long-Term Planning and Consistent Execution** 7 **COLM 2026**
  Muyu He[*], Adit Jain[*], Anand Kumar[*], Vincent Tu[*], Soumyadeep Bakshi, Sachin Patro, Nazneen Rajani
  - Curated the first long-horizon benchmark spanning years of effort to task the agent with running a company, effectively distinguishing models' ability to schedule tasks, manage budget, and manage clients.

- **High-fidelity Simulations of Human Traits for Testing Agents** 11 **ACL Oral 2026**
  Muyu He[*], Anand Kumar[*], Meghana Arakkal Rajeev[*], Soumyadeep Bakshi[*], James Zou, Nazneen Rajani
  - Improved a training-free technique for fine-grained, arbitrary control over LLM personality by extracting per-layer activations that correspond to human traits (impatience, confusion, etc.)

- **Evaluating Deductive Reasoning via Detective Games** 9 **EMNLP 2025**
  Yuan Yuan[*], **Muyu He**[*], Adil Shahid, Jiani Huang, Ziyang Li, Li Zhang

- **Commonsense-T2I Challenge: Can Text-to-Image Generation Models Understand Commonsense?** 54 **COLM 2024**
  Xingyu Fu[*], **Muyu He**[*], Yujie Lu, William Yang Wang, Dan Roth

Work Experience

Research Scientist **June 2026 - Current**
Zyphra *San Francisco, US*

- *Zaya* (Sparse attention + MoE model family) 🤗
  - Trained novel test-time techniques end-to-end with RL on in-house 74B-A3B models, managing the entire lifecycle of data curation, reward design, and inference optimization.
  - Developed new async RL algorithms under training-inference mismatches up to 16 steps, such as sign-based KL losses, to improve training stability.

Research Scientist **July 2025 - June 2026**
Collinear.ai *Sunnyvale, US*

- *Spider* (popular on-policy distillation framework) ★110
  - Implemented cross-tokenizer alignment to enable on-policy distillation on any teacher-student model pairs, resolving chat-template issues in existing algorithms by HuggingFace
  - Enabled a token-in-token-out protocol for multi-turn rollouts with robust bug patches for standing tokenizers (e.g. Qwen3), extending on-policy distillation to agentic tool use without mismatch issues
- *Computer-use RL environments* (provider for 3 frontier labs on CUA capabilities)
  - Developed a robust automated environment generation pipeline spanning task generation, verifier generation, data seeding, and Docker runtime setup across 11 real-world apps (e.g. Slack, Asana, Figma, GitHub)
  - Discovered systematic insights on fundamental failure modes in CUA of frontier models (Claude, GPT), enabling the design of RL-efficient tasks in the environment with 33–66% Pass@1

Open-source Projects

RiddleHe/nanochat ★59
- Built a hackable pretraining stack from karpathy/nanochat that supports easy definition of architecture and rigorous FLOP-controlled ablations
- Shipped a mirrored RL stack for RL algorithm research that allows clean objective definition with production-grade vLLM inference serving

RiddleHe/llm-interp ★92
- Authored a series of completely reproducible interpretability scripts to conduct model circuit research
- Produced findings on attention sinks (the existence of massive activations in 1-2 dimensions for Qwen3 models only on the first tokens) and an open-source reproduction of Thinking Machines' finding on LLM decode indeterminism

RiddleHe/gpt-oss-alignment ★123
- Jailbroke the RL-aligned GPT-OSS-20B model via simple chat-template removal, revealing the fragility of post-training alignment that relies on priors of the assistant chat format
- Provided a popular technique to arbitrarily manipulate responses from GPT-OSS-20B by steering activations corresponding to traits, and implemented an end-to-end framework for training its sparse autoencoders